



SOCIAL SUPPORT

An Established Support Network

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9x

People with high levels of resilience are 9x more likely to have an established support network than those with low levels of resilience

93%

of people with **high levels** of resilience have an established support network

75%

of people with **average levels** of resilience have an established support network

9%

of people with **low levels** of resilience have an established support network

The Importance of Having a Strong Support Network for Resilience



The ability to bounce back from adversity, is significantly enhanced by having a robust support network. This network plays a crucial role in providing emotional, informational, and practical support, which are essential for overcoming challenges and maintaining mental health.



EMOTIONAL SUPPORT

Stress Reduction: Sharing worries and fears with supportive friends or family members can alleviate stress and provide comfort.

Validation: Supportive individuals offer validation of feelings, which can normalise emotional responses and reduce feelings of isolation.

Encouragement: Positive reinforcement from others can boost self-esteem and motivation, helping individuals to keep going even when times are tough.



INFORMATIONAL SUPPORT

Guidance: Experienced members of a support network can provide advice and insights based on their own experiences.

Problem-Solving: Collaborating with others can lead to new perspectives and solutions that one might not have considered alone.

Learning Resources: Access to information and resources through a network can facilitate better decision-making and coping strategies.



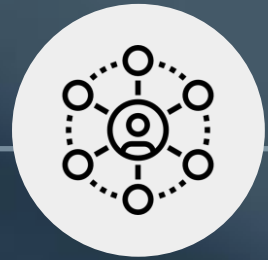
PRACTICAL SUPPORT

Assistance: Help with tasks or responsibilities can alleviate burdens and provide relief during difficult times.

Resource Sharing: Networks can offer tangible resources such as financial assistance, tools, or other necessities.

Opportunities: Connections within a network can lead to new opportunities for personal and professional growth.

Building a Strong Support Network - Best Practice



Cultivate Diverse Relationships

- Variety of Perspectives: Connect with people from different backgrounds to gain various viewpoints and experiences.
- Broad Support: Ensure your network includes friends, family, colleagues, and community members to cover different aspects of support.



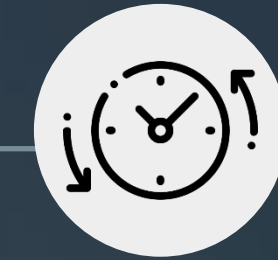
Foster Mutual Support and Reciprocity

- Two-Way Relationships: Engage in relationships where both parties give and receive support.
- Build Trust and Respect: Develop trust through reliability and respect, which are foundational for strong, supportive relationships.



Effective Communication

- Openness: Be honest and clear about your needs and feelings.
- Active Listening: Practice attentive listening to understand and empathise with others.
- Regular Check-Ins: Maintain consistent communication to keep relationships strong and responsive.



Engage in Regular Interaction

- Consistent Engagement: Make an effort to stay in touch regularly, not just during times of crisis.
- Quality Time: Spend meaningful time with your support network through activities and shared interests.



Seek and Offer Help

- Don't Hesitate to Ask: Reach out for support when needed; people are often willing to help.
- Be Available to Others: Offer your support to others in your network, fostering a culture of mutual assistance.



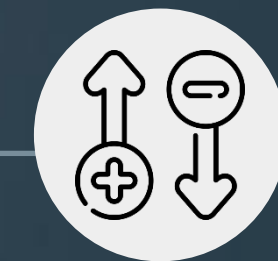
Invest in Long-Term Relationships

- Nurture Connections: Invest time and effort into maintaining and deepening relationships over the long term.
- Reliability: Be dependable and trustworthy, showing that you can be counted on.



Balance Your Network

- Avoid Over-Reliance: Ensure you're not relying too heavily on one person for all types of support.
- Diversify Sources: Have different people for different kinds of support—emotional, practical, and informational.



Create Positive Environments

- Positive Interactions: Engage in positive, uplifting interactions that reinforce supportive relationships.
- Healthy Boundaries: Set and respect boundaries to maintain healthy and sustainable relationships.

Strong Relationships With Parents and Siblings

Research suggests that strong relationships with parents and siblings can significantly contribute to higher levels of resilience. Here is a summary of the key evidence:



Attachment Theory

Secure attachment with parents fosters resilience by creating a foundation of safety and stability, aiding stress management.



Emotional Support

Consistent emotional support from parents and siblings helps children cope with challenges and recover from setbacks.



Social Learning

Parents model coping strategies; observing and imitating these, along with positive sibling interactions, builds resilience and social skills.



Sense of Belonging

Feeling accepted within the family boosts self-esteem and confidence, key elements of resilience.



Communication and Problem-Solving

Open dialogue and joint problem-solving in families promote emotional expression, critical thinking, and adaptability.



Longitudinal Studies

Long-term studies have shown that strong early family bonds are linked to greater adult resilience, highlighting their long-term impact.



Strong relationships with parents and siblings are integral to developing resilience. These relationships provide emotional support, role modelling, a sense of belonging, and effective communication practices, all of which contribute to an individual's ability to withstand and recover from challenges.

Best Practice

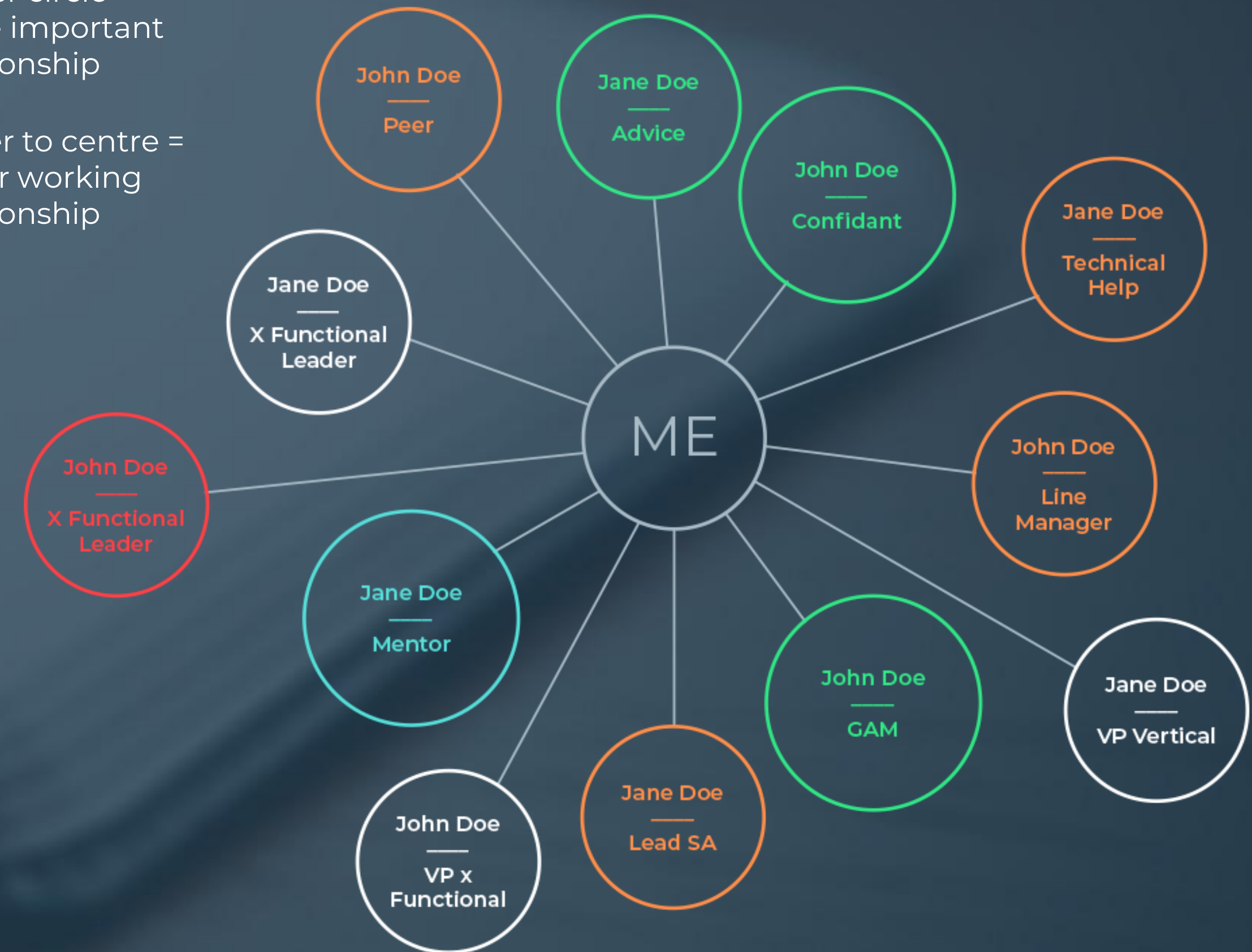
Defining Your Personal Network – Home & Work

- Identify the important relationships in your life – family, friends and colleagues.
- Consider the depth and closeness of these relationships.
- Do you have people you can turn to for help when things get tough?
- Create your personal network map and identify gaps and relationships you may need to work on.

Personal Network Map

Larger circle =
more important
relationship

Closer to centre =
closer working
relationship



● Mentor/Coach

● Supporter

● Neutral

● Negative/Enemy

● Unknown

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EXERCISE 1

Building your Personal Network Map

Ask yourself:

- Do you have a strong network of people you can turn to?
- Who do you turn to in any given situation?

Now map out your network with these simple steps:

1

Using a piece of paper or online application draw a circle in the middle. This is you!

2

You are now going to draw your network depicted as other circles. You may want to define your professional and personal networks separately or on the same map.

3

Now add people from your network to the map as follows:

- Place people whom you have a closer relationship nearer to you on the network map with the circle in a solid line.
- Place people whom you don't have a close relationship further away from you.
- Draw a bigger circle for people who have greater importance in your life.
- Colour code the different circles as follows to assess the quality of the relationship;
 - Blue: Mentor/coach
 - Green: Supporter
 - Orange: Neutral
 - Red: Negative/enemy
 - White: Unknown
- Add to each circle the person's name and role/what you need/get from them

4

Assess your network map and consider the following:

- What do you want from these individuals?
- What can you offer in return?
- Which relationships do you need to strengthen?
- Do you have all aspects of your professional and personal support covered or are there any gaps?
- If there are gaps, identify who could provide the support you are looking for in that area.

5

Build an action plan to broaden and deepen your relationships.

Important qualities to look for when deciding who might be a good person to confide in



Empathetic



Good listener



Non judgemental



Trustworthy



Confidential



Independent

Sometimes it's easier to open up to a stranger

Best Practice

Internal Stakeholder Management at Work

- Take a proactive approach to managing internal stakeholders – people who are important to the success of a project, your customer or your career.
- Identify, prioritise and engage with your internal stakeholders using the power/relevance matrix.
- Focus on developing regular communication and cadence with the key people in your network.

The Power/Relevance Matrix

